in. The *gaala* or the money box that's kept in the chai stall is the one that my father used. It's a small wooden box with a photo of goddess Laxmi stuck inside. We even shot in the theatre that my family watched movies at. It had been defunct for almost 25 years and we refurbished it."

When the film's selection was announced in September, Nalin's film attracted a lot of negativity. This, understandably, took the sheen off what was a big moment for the maker and his team. "My friend Tearepa Kahi, a Kiwi filmmaker whose film *Muru* is New Zealand's entry to the Oscars, told me that he and his film were being celebrated in his country, while we were getting so much backlash here."

As the online hate has petered out, Nalin has had a moment to understand the hostility. "We are a nation of such diversity, so it is a tough task to choose one film to represent the country. It's almost like asking the European Union to pick only one film. I can't even imagine how challenging a job it is for the FFI [Film Federation of India] to pick one amongst this variety of blockbusters with stars to small films where the director has done everything from editing to shooting the film."

Chhelo Show's Oscar campaign started with the film's commercial release on October 14 and it will now be screened for Academy members across the world. "Our American and international distributors, Samuel Goldwyn Films and Orange Studios, have a history of bringing films to the Academy's attention. Last year, Samuel Goldwyn backed Bhutan's *Lunana: A Yak in the Classroom* and Denmark's 2020 film, *Another Round*. I am completely trusting them to prepare the Oscar campaign." ■

Karishma Upadhyay

FILMS

KNOCKING ON THE ACADEMY'S DOOR

India's Oscar story is one of sudden glory and narrow misses

In **1957**, the year that the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences first instituted the award for Best International Feature Film, India almost struck gold. Not only was Mehboob Khan's epic saga *Mother India* nominated, it lost out to Federico Fellini's *Nights of Cabiria* by just one vote in the end.



Nominated in **1969** for Best Documentary (Short Subject), Fali Bilimoria's *The House that Ananda Built* follows a successful businessman in Nagpur, looking at his life and beliefs. In **1979**, K.K. Kapil's documentary, *An Encounter with Faces*, was again nominated in this Oscar category.

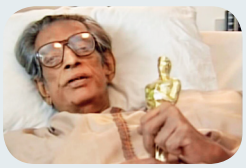
Richard Attenborough's *Gandhi* won eight Oscars in **1983**. But the one that India celebrated most keenly was its win for Costume Design. That year, Bhanu Athaiya became the first Indian to bring back a golden Oscar from Los Angeles.



A Room with a View earned its producer, Ismail Merchant, a Best Picture nomination in **1987**. He was nominated for two more James Ivory-directed films—*Howard's End* (1993) and *The Remains of the Day* (1997)—but, sadly, that Oscar was always out of his reach.

In **1989**, Mira Nair's debut film *Salaam Bombay* became the second Indian film to be nominated for Best International Feature Film. Set in a Mumbai red-light district, Nair told the story of a disadvantaged teaboy with disarming charm.

Satyajit Ray was admitted in a Kolkata hospital in **1992** when given an Honorary Academy Award "in recognition of his rare mastery of the art of motion pictures, and of his profound humanitarian outlook, which has had an indelible influence on filmmakers and audiences throughout the world".





With its long cricket matches, song-and-dance sequences and a running time of nearly four hours, no one expected *Lagaan* to get far at the Oscars. But surprisingly, it became India's third Best Foreign Language Film nominee in **2002** and was a favourite till the very end.

Slumdog Millionaire may well have had a British director (Danny Boyle) and producer (Christian Colson), but the film gave India its greatest Oscar moment in **2009**. Sound designer Resul Pookutty, Gulzar and A.R. Rahman all won Academy Awards for their contributions to this musical extravaganza.



A film about journalism, *Writing with Fire* tells the story of how the all-female newspaper *Khabar Lahariya* risks much in their quest for truth. Nominated for Best Documentary Feature in **2022**, the film courted controversy when the news portal questioned how its work had been portrayed.